



The pull of unfinished business

South Africa has turned to **experience and emotion** in its bid for a maiden Women's T20 World Cup title, recalling Shabnim Ismail and Dane van Niekerk for the 2026 campaign after years of retirements, heartbreak, and near misses.

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On May 11, South Africa was scheduled to announce its squad for the Women's T20 World Cup to be played in England in June-July. Minutes before the scheduled online announcement was to go live, Cricket South Africa reportedly announced a postponement due to the need for further internal reviews.

Cue dramatic drumbeat. In an era of major churn in the women's game, the Proteas line-up, in its bid to finally secure maiden ICC silverware, has been closely watched. Australia's cloak of invincibility seems to have slipped; New Zealand is undergoing a major transition, while India and England are still grappling with consistency.

In the 2023 T20 World Cup, Meg Lanning's world-beating Australia could not be denied by a spirited Proteas outfit. Shabnim Ismail was part of the heartbroken squad that

watched the Aussies collect their winners' medals. Dane van Niekerk, part of the ICC commentary panel for the tournament after failing to make the squad, was equally desolate. The pair announced their retirement from the game, the former wanting more time for family, the latter disgruntled by her controversial exclusion on fitness grounds. Both expressed unhappiness with the erstwhile management on their way out. A spectacular collapse in the final deprived South Africa again in 2024, when Suzie Bates, Sophie Devine,